

Baroque in Flanders

Political and religious differences in northwestern Europe led to the formation of two independent states. Holland (the present-day Netherlands) broke from Spain at the end of the 16th century, while Flanders (modern Belgium and part of northern France) remained part of the Spanish Roman Catholic Empire into the 17th century.

Antwerp and Brussels became leading art centres, with religious subjects paramount. The art was vibrant and accomplished. Rubens exemplified the culture through his dynamic and exuberant Baroque style. His influence on Flemish art was huge, and many students trained at his busy studio, including Anthony van Dyck (1599–1641) who became Rubens's chief assistant while still a teenager. Van Dyck painted religious and mythological scenes, but was primarily a brilliant portraitist, in demand in European courts, and particularly in England. Jan Brueghel the Younger (1601–78) followed his father and painted landscapes, allegorical scenes and other subjects in meticulous detail.



Judith Leyster, *Young Flute Player*, c.1635